ABOUT THE ORIGINAL STUDY

Examining the Teacher Labor Market in Different Rural Contexts: Variations by Urbanicity and Rural States

Study authors: Nguyen, T. D.

Why It Matters

Rural staffing challenges depend on how rurality is defined. This study distinguishes rural schools, less urbanized states, and sparsely populated states to examine differences obscured by a single rural label.

Data and Sample

The study uses four waves of nationally representative Schools and Staffing Survey data and teacher follow-up information. Rural contexts are defined at both school and state levels.

Key Findings

- Teachers in rural schools were less likely to turn over than those in urban-suburban schools, while turnover was higher in sparsely populated states.
- Novice and special education teachers were especially vulnerable to turnover in several rural contexts; STEM teachers did not show the same consistent pattern.
- Administrative support, staff cooperation, and union membership were associated with lower turnover, while underserved rural schools faced particular retention challenges.

Policy Implications

- Tailor staffing policies to specific rural contexts rather than treating rurality as homogeneous.
- Prioritize support for novice teachers, special educators, and teachers of color in vulnerable rural settings.
- Consider administrative support and collaboration as retention priorities, while testing interventions rather than interpreting associations as causal effects.

Full Citation and Paper Link:
Nguyen, T. D. (2020). Examining the Teacher Labor Market in Different Rural Contexts: Variations by Urbanicity and Rural States. *AERA Open*, 6(4), 2332858420966336.
Read the full paper: https://doi.org/10.1177/2332858420966336

Acknowledgment and Disclaimer:
This brief was produced with support from the Walton Family Foundation. The ERRE Center summarizes the original research; any errors in this summary are the responsibility of the center. The findings and interpretations presented do not necessarily reflect the views of the center or its funders. Readers should consult the original paper for complete findings and details.